

my fellow average investor by passing along all the knowledge I've gained. I hope you'll applaud my selfless efforts on your behalf.

You may also be wondering what sort of expertise qualifies me to speak out on financial matters, an issue I'll address more fully in a moment. I hope this doesn't sound like bragging, but being a stranger to Wall Street turned out to have been a terrific advantage. Unburdened by important connections and free of the weight of any previous knowledge, I could ask such apparently stupid questions as: "What is a Treasury bill?" or "Why do stocks go up and down?" and inquire about the basic facts that average investors often pretend to know already, since we're too embarrassed to admit our ignorance.

Just as many experts sprinkle tips and rules of investing throughout their books and articles, I offer my own tips and rules as often as possible. Since mine are based on actual experience, hard evidence, and/or irrefutable logic, you can have complete confidence in every one of them.

In preparing for this wealth-building journey, I realized how much I'd been thinking about money in recent years. Thinking about money is a well-known consequence of middle age. As the waist expands and the arteries contract, sex seems to take a merciful back seat in the libido, supplanted by an obsession with where to eat and how to increase one's net worth. The frequency of thought has no apparent correlation to practical success in either instance.

When you get right down to it, thinking about money has become the national pastime. Regardless of how much or how little you may have, you are almost forced to contemplate assets from day-break to midnight. If I'm any example, the average person is being flooded with opportunities in stocks, bonds, mutual funds, options, commodities, certificates of deposit, Ginnie Maes, or the additional equity that can be squeezed from the house.

You can't browse at a magazine counter without glimpsing some investment headline in the current *Money*, *Fortune*, *Forbes*, *Institutional Investor*, *Business Week*, *Inc.*, *Barron's*, *Nation's Business*, *Future*, *Venture*, or *Personal Investing*, not to mention the *Wall Street Journal* and *Investor's Daily*. There are endless special